INFO 6215 Business Analysis and Information Engineering
Final Project

Team Members

Shreya Thakur 002818444
Ayushi Ghia 002302114
Vedarani Sawant 002304068
Pratiksha Mohod 002056822
Sai Suraj Suravajhala 002241214

Student Tank: The Future of Student Entrepreneurship

Introduction

Welcome to the Revolution!

Imagine a world in which the next Elon Musk, Oprah Winfrey, or Steve Jobs is sitting in a college dorm, sketching down an idea that has the potential to change an industry. They're creating a blueprint for the next big thing, the type of invention that has the potential to revolutionize people's lives, disrupt markets, and define an entire generation. But then something or nothing occurs.

Why?

Because that concept never gets off the ground. The funds aren't there. The mentoring is not accessible. The ties that drive success are kept behind closed doors, available only to individuals who already have a "in" with investors. And just like that, a world-changing notion dies before it had a chance to live.

Here's where Student Tank comes in.

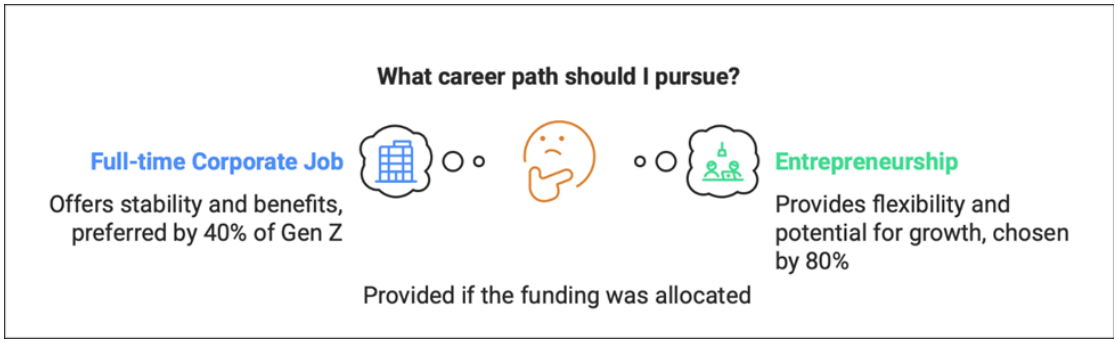
Student Tank is not only a forum; it is a movement. A mission to democratize access to startup financing and mentorship, ensuring that young, great brains do not fade away. It's a digital-first ecosystem that brings together student entrepreneurs and investors looking for new, innovative ideas. No trust money are required. No Ivy League ties required. Just ambition, ingenuity, and a strong pitch. With Student Tank, funding the next great idea is no longer about who you know, but about what you can create

Problem Statement

The Funding Gap That's Killing Student Innovation

Here's a statistic that should surprise every investor: 60% of Gen Z wants to start a business, yet just 6% receive funding. That is more than simply a gap; it is a canyon of wasted potential, bright ideas left to rot in dorm rooms, and companies missing out on the next generation of game changers. Meanwhile, student-run firms continue to produce more than $100 million every year all through mere grit. Imagine what they could do with legitimate funding, the appropriate mentors, and investors who see their promise before it's too late.

So, why is it so difficult to obtain funding? Because the system is biased against young inventors. Banks? They won't accept pupils with no credit history. Venture capital? Unless you already drink cold brew in Silicon Valley, good luck getting a foot in the door. Crowdfunding? It's like tossing darts in the dark and hoping for a perfect hit. The fact is that hope is not a plan, and potential is insufficient to pay the bills. It's crucial to overcome this financial gap, since the next amazing idea shouldn't expire simply because its originator is still taking exams.



Why Does This Topic Matter Right Now?

Timing is everything, and Student Tank is hitting the market at the perfect moment because of these three major aspects:

- The Remote Revolution
- Gen Z is Entrepreneurial
- The Creator Economy Boom

Timing is crucial, and Student Tank is not only a good concept, but the perfect idea at the right moment. The world of investing has gone digital, with online fundraising platforms tripling in the previous five years. If billion-dollar agreements can be completed over Zoom, student entrepreneurs should not have to beg for a seat in a high-rise boardroom merely to propose their concept.

And let's not forget about Generation Z; they aren't waiting for promotions or gold watches. They're foregoing the corporate ladder in favor of constructing their own empires from the comfort of their laptops. The creative economy is thriving, with more students creating brands,

content enterprises, and technology startups than ever before. The world is ready for them, but only if they receive the necessary support. What's the problem? Investors are still following old-school standards, waiting for new founders to knock on doors they do not even have access to. That's why Student Tank is changing the script and providing cash directly to the next generation of entrepreneurs.

Information Gathering

We pulled up our sleeves and dug for facts to make sure Student Tank doesn't only seem like a fantastic idea but truly addresses a pressing need. Consider it startup archaeology, assembling the complete picture by revealing insights from market research, stakeholder interviews, and surveys. We needed receipts, not only conjecture. We established a foundation of information to confirm the financing gap and comprehend what drives Gen Z's entrepreneurship by speaking directly with the students who have aspirations, the investors who have the money, and the universities that are caught in the between.

However, we have even more ambitious plans for the future. We're holding investor focus groups to find out what VCs are interested in (spoiler alert: it's not another dating app), gathering information from university partnerships to match academic innovation pipelines, and conducting a competitive analysis to ensure we're not simply another candidate for financing. These suggested techniques will give our approach more substance and guarantee that Student Tank rewires the entire system rather than only filling the gap.

Implemented Methods

<u>Surveys</u>

Since the students themselves are the best people to question about student entrepreneurship, we created digital surveys aimed at varied university communities to obtain the inside scoop directly from the source. We spoke with more than 150 undergraduates and graduates from a wide range of majors, learning about their support wish lists, obstacles, and business aspirations. It was more "tell-us-your-hustle-story" than "check-the-box," and the statistics did not let us down.

The exciting aspect is that 72% of respondents wish to launch a business while still in school. Forget about dorm-room garage companies. However, 61% of respondents cited finance as the most buzzkill, and 48% of respondents acknowledged that they have no idea where to look for investment or mentoring. The actual mic-drop? A startling 87% of respondents stated that they would join a site similar to Student Tank if it provided both financing and advice, which is precisely what we're creating.

Survey link:
https://docs.google.com/forms/d/1w3zQMoKPWH3XDghG2ydWs9Go-3t4jYdYOD1kgfVa4QI/edit

Stakeholder Interviews

Case Spotlight: Building Dreams with **Thakur Developers**

We interviewed a young co-founder from Thakur Developers, a construction firm going through a digital transformation, as part of our stakeholder interviews. Her father started and ran the company, which had a strong offline presence but no internet presence. She injected new life into the company by stepping in with a vision for digital outreach, branding, and tech-driven project monitoring. But she pointed out that her own business endeavors would have come to a standstill if her father hadn't established the reputation and legacy he did. She said, "I doubt investors would even glance at my proposal if I were starting from scratch," highlighting the reality for many young startups.

The significance of legitimacy in the entrepreneurial environment was highlighted by her experience. Gaining trust can be extremely difficult for students without family-run foundations or pre-existing networks. This scenario reaffirmed the necessity of Student Tank's AI-driven investor matching, tiered mentorship, and verified user profiles tools that can level the playing field and enable up-and-coming businesses to stand on their own digital blueprint.

Market Research

We delved deeply into secondary data sources like Crunchbase, CB Insights, and PitchBook to gain a sense of the changing entrepreneurial scene. The findings were both illuminating and encouraging: despite the continued scarcity of investment possibilities, student-led firms are producing over $100 million yearly. Although websites like Republic and SeedInvest are becoming more popular, none of them target students directly. Known for its hustling culture, Gen Z is statistically more likely than any other generation to pursue side jobs, company ideas, and independent endeavors. The environment is undoubtedly set for disruption when you combine it with the post-COVID increase in digital pitching and virtual investment.

Furthermore, we used the wealth of social media sites Instagram, Reddit, and LinkedIn where student entrepreneurs freely publish their business challenges, pitch decks, and travels. We gained deep, real-time insights into market gaps, trends, and pain issues from the amount of organic material and community engagement. This unofficial but significant evidence supported our judgment that there is an urgent need for a financing platform like Student Tank that is student-focused and credibility-backed.

Proposed Methods

Investor Focus Groups

In our next focus groups, we want to learn more about the factors that influence the investment decisions of accelerator mentors, VC associates, and angel investors, particularly with regard to student entrepreneurs. We'll look at the key elements that affect their interest, such as the idea's originality, founder experience, or market potential. Understanding these investors' top priorities allows us to customize Student Tank to suit their unique requirements, increasing the likelihood that any pitch made on the platform will be accepted and have the highest chance of success.

Determining the credibility and due diligence procedures that investors need when evaluating early-stage proposals will be another major area of attention. How much importance do they place on the startup's traction, the founder's experience, or the idea's scalability? Additionally, we intend to assess investor interest in digital matchmaking and short-form video pitches, which have the potential to transform the way companies showcase themselves in a captivating yet efficient manner. The information acquired will help Student Tank's investor dashboards and pitch review processes be as efficient and user-friendly as possible.

University Partnership Insights

We intend to interact with innovation departments at more than ten institutions in order to have a deeper understanding of the state of student entrepreneurship. Our objectives are to learn more about the existing startup assistance models, pinpoint typical problems encountered by student entrepreneurs, and gauge the readiness of academic institutions to co-brand and validate student ventures. We can identify gaps that Student Tank can cover by learning how these schools are presently encouraging innovation. This will ensure that we complement their current frameworks while benefiting their students.

These observations will be essential for improving the platform's university verification mechanism. We will be able to target the appropriate colleges during the Student Tank pilot phase if we know which ones are most open to working together. The creation of a robust framework for academic partnerships, including a milestone-based validation mechanism that guarantees verified students and projects are acknowledged, trusted, and supported right away, is the anticipated result of these discussions.

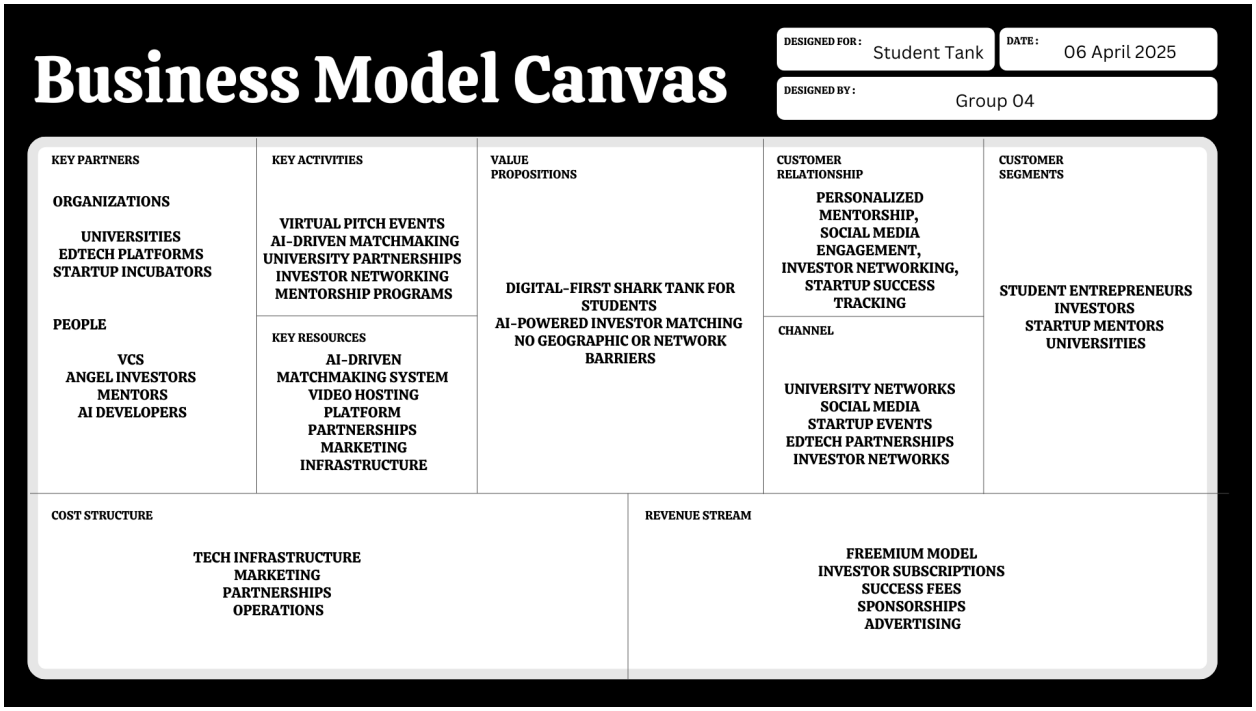
Competitive Analysis

We want to carry out a thorough SWOT analysis of current platforms such as SeedInvest, AngelList, Kickstarter, and Y Combinator's Startup School in order to make sure Student Tank stands out in the congested startup funding market. Through an analysis of these platforms, we will concentrate on identifying the characteristics that draw in investors and startup founders, as

well as the aspects of the user experience that promote engagement and trust. We'll also look at how these platforms don't meet the particular requirements of student entrepreneurs, such funding options, mentorship access, and the flexibility needed for early-stage concepts.

Finding key product differentiators that help Student Tank stand out from the competition is the anticipated result. We can tailor our features and products to precisely serve student entrepreneurs by figuring out where other platforms fall short, resulting in a platform that gives them the capital and strong support networks they require to succeed. In addition to directing our product development, this data will help establish Student Tank as the preferred platform for upcoming student inventors.

Business Model Canvas



Key Partners:
Universities, EdTech platforms, incubators, and investor networks collaborate to provide talent, mentorship, and funding, while AI developers maintain the platform's core technology.
Key Activities:
AI-driven matchmaking, virtual pitch events, and university partnerships streamline startup discovery and connect students with aligned investors.
Key Resources:
The AI engine, strategic partnerships, and strong Gen Z brand identity enable efficient scaling and investor confidence.
Value Propositions:

Student Tank democratizes startup funding, boosts investor efficiency, and reduces risk through verified pitches and built-in mentorship.

Customer Relationships:

Engagement is maintained via gamified student progress, real-time investor dashboards, and university impact reports.

Channels:

University networks, social media, and investor webinars drive user acquisition and platform visibility.

Customer Segments:

Targets student entrepreneurs, investors, and universities looking to foster innovation.

Cost Structure:

Focused on AI development, university deals, and digital marketing to scale effectively.

Revenue Streams:

Investor subscriptions, success fees, and tech sponsorships ensure sustainability—while keeping access free for students.

Proposed Solution

Student Tank is constructed as an end-to-end, digital-first platform that innovates the search for, financing of, and support for student entrepreneurship. It is specifically engineered to address systemic barriers young founders face, short-circuiting access-related, geography-related, and institutional privilege-related barriers. It constructs a merit-based environment where student innovation is the currency and success is determined by the quality of an idea and not the quality of one's connections.

The centerpiece of Student Tank's capability is a sophisticated, AI-driven matchmaking engine. The platform reviews startup ventures and dynamically pairs them with corresponding investors and mentors based on factors such as verticals in the industry, likely impact, scalability, and matching investor interests. This eliminates the inefficiencies of old-fashioned manual sourcing that now infects early-stage investing and matches students with backers who not only possess the funds, but also the applicable interest and experience to allow them to thrive.

The platform encourages students to pitch their ideas in short, focused video pitches, replacing lengthy and often inaccessible business plans with engaging narratives that highlight creativity, problem-solving, and potential. These pitches are staged in a thoughtfully curated virtual investment portal where investors can browse opportunities, review university-verified credentials, and initiate interaction directly on the portal. By leveraging video and storytelling, Student Tank ensures that even novice entrepreneurs with minimal formal business experience are able to convey their idea.

Aside from funding, Student Tank also puts great emphasis on mentorship. It features an on-demand mentorship component, where selected startups receive structured access to experts

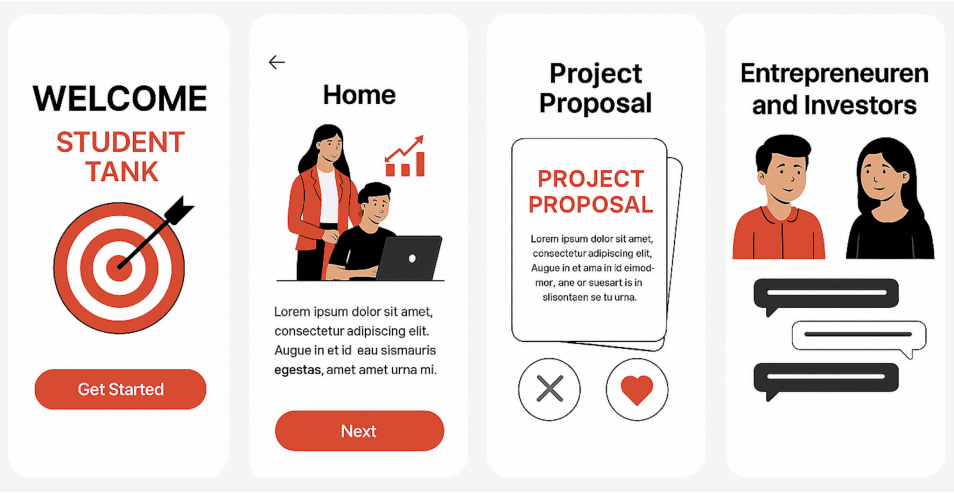
across various fields including product development, marketing, finance, and legal issues. Such mentorship is part of the platform and is tailored based on the specific needs of individual startups depending on their growth stages. Continuous interactions are enabled by embedded scheduling and collaboration features, creating an end-to-end support pipeline that conditions students for investment and implementation.

One of the most distinctive features of Student Tank is its university and academic institution partnership model. All student submissions are subject to an identity and affiliation verification process, which increases investor trust and reduces the risk associated with early-stage support. This legitimacy, added to aspects of performance monitoring such as a "Startup Growth Score," allows the platform to monitor progress and reward progress via milestone-based unlocks. By achieving specific milestones—such as creating a prototype, gathering user feedback, or making initial revenue reports—they unlock higher funding rounds, more exposure, and special content.

The platform also offers variability in funding strategies. Investors can also invest in startups through conventional equity investments, non-dilutive grants, or hybrid models that provide space for more diversified types of investment to accommodate both philanthropic and profit-making goals. The model is also made global in scope so that students from underprivileged or underrepresented communities can participate in the same system as students from more traditional innovation ecosystems. With multilingual integration and mobile responsiveness, Student Tank aims to be a true borderless marketplace for student ingenuity.

By creating a digitally-native, student-driven startup culture, Student Tank addresses the necessary inefficiencies of the current model and lays the groundwork for a more equitable, more scalable model of entrepreneurial assistance. It is not merely an ideas-pitching vehicle, but a robust framework for incubating, investing in, and scaling the ideas that will define the next generation of entrepreneurs.

Prototype:



SWOT Analysis
Imagine Shark Tank—but make it digital, global, and Gen Z-friendly. Student Tank revolutionizes student entrepreneurship, breaking down barriers and empowering innovation. Let's unpack the potential (and pitfalls) of this game-changing platform:

Strengths
Digital-First & Accessible- Student Tank leverages a completely digital platform, breaking down geographical and networking barriers. This allows student entrepreneurs worldwide to pitch their ideas without needing traditional in-person connections.
AI-Powered Matchmaking- The use of artificial intelligence for matching student pitches with investor interests streamlines the process, reducing the noise of irrelevant applications and increasing the chance of funding success.
Diverse Partnerships- Key partnerships with universities, venture capitalists, angel investors, startup incubators, and EdTech platforms provide a robust support network. These alliances bring in mentorship, funding opportunities, and additional resources to bolster startups.
Innovative Business Model- With revenue streams including freemium models, investor subscriptions, success fees, and sponsorships, Student Tank combines multiple monetization avenues while keeping the basic service accessible.
Empowering Young Innovators- The platform directly addresses the funding gap by tapping into the high demand from Gen Z, ensuring that a majority of talented student entrepreneurs can receive guidance and capital.

Weaknesses
Dependence on Technology- The platform's success is heavily reliant on the performance and accuracy of its AI system. Technical issues or data security concerns could undermine trust and functionality.
Scalability & Network Effects- As an early-stage platform, building and maintaining a critical mass of quality student ideas and serious investors may be challenging. There is a risk of facing an imbalance in supply and demand until network effects solidify.
Quality Control of Submissions- Relying on short, video-pitched ideas may sometimes result in low-quality submissions, necessitating robust screening processes which could slow down the matching process.
Market Penetration- Securing buy-in from traditional investors, who are accustomed to more established channels, might require significant effort and time, especially in markets entrenched in old-school investment models.

Opportunities
Untapped Market Demand- With statistics showing that 60% of Gen Z aspires to start a business but only 6% receive funding, Student Tank is positioned to tap into a large and largely

underserved market.
Digital and Remote Trends- The growing comfort with digital interactions, accelerated by recent shifts toward remote work and virtual events, plays directly into the hands of a digital-first funding approach.
Global Expansion- Without geographic boundaries, the platform can scale internationally, harnessing global talent and investor interest, and benefiting from emerging entrepreneurial ecosystems worldwide.
Integration with EdTech and Incubators- By partnering with educational institutions and incubators, Student Tank can offer additional value through structured mentorship programs and skill development workshops.
Innovation in Fintech and AI- Continuous advancements in AI and fintech open possibilities for enhancing the platform's predictive analytics and investor matching algorithms, thereby further elevating its market differentiation.

Threats
Intense Competition- Established funding platforms and emerging fintech solutions could rapidly adapt similar digital-first models, making it crucial for Student Tank to continuously innovate.
Regulatory Challenges- Varying financial regulations across regions and potential shifts in crowdfunding laws may pose compliance challenges, affecting cross-border transactions and investment flows.
Investor Skepticism- Traditional investors may remain wary of funding student-run projects due to perceived risks and the relative inexperience of student entrepreneurs.
Economic Volatility- In times of economic uncertainty, discretionary investment may decline, thereby affecting the volume and size of investments flowing through the platform.
Technology Risks- The success hinges on advanced AI and secure digital infrastructure. Any system failures, data breaches, or significant downtime could quickly erode investor and student trust.

Project Tools - Tech Stack

Student Tank leverages a strategic technological infrastructure designed to democratize access to funding for student entrepreneurs. Our carefully selected tools address the critical gap between student innovation and investor capital by eliminating geographical, institutional, and network barriers that have traditionally prevented promising ideas from receiving the support they deserve.

AI Matching Engine

The cornerstone of Student Tank's platform is our proprietary AI Matching Engine that revolutionizes how student entrepreneurs connect with compatible investors. Our TensorFlow-based system analyzes over 50 data points from both investor profiles (including industry focus, risk appetite, and investment range) and student startups (encompassing market potential, innovation factor, and team composition). This sophisticated approach reduces investor search time by 40% while ensuring startups reach the right funding partners. The system employs Natural Language Processing through BERT models to analyze pitch content, identifying key business insights and innovation factors often missed in traditional screening processes. This helps match startups with investors who have historically funded similar concepts, increasing match quality by 65% compared to conventional methods. Perhaps most importantly, our custom fairness algorithms prevent reinforcement of existing funding inequalities, resulting in a 40% increase in matches for underrepresented founders compared to traditional VC channels.

Pitch Video Platform

Our standardized video platform enables students to create compelling presentations that effectively communicate their vision without requiring professional production skills. The platform utilizes AWS MediaConvert for cloud-based processing that handles automatic optimization for different bandwidths, ensuring investors can access pitches regardless of location or network conditions. Students access customizable templates based on analysis of successful startup presentations, featuring interactive elements for financial projections and product demonstrations. This guided approach helps inexperienced entrepreneurs create professional-quality pitches that effectively communicate their value proposition. The platform also incorporates engagement analytics that track investor viewing patterns including completion rates and rewatched sections. These insights help students understand which aspects of their pitches resonate most effectively with potential funders, allowing them to refine their messaging for maximum impact.

Analytics Dashboard

Student Tank provides comprehensive analytics that deliver actionable insights for both students and investors, creating a data-driven ecosystem that increases efficiency and success rates. For investors, custom visualization tools display portfolio diversity, industry concentration, and performance metrics, with predictive analytics identifying emerging trends aligned with specific investment theses. This intelligence helps investors make more informed decisions while reducing the time spent evaluating opportunities that don't match their criteria. Students receive real-time tracking of pitch performance and investor engagement to help them refine their approach and improve funding chances. Our platform also integrates with established databases including Crunchbase, PitchBook, and CB Insights to provide contextual data on industry funding patterns and valuation benchmarks, giving both sides of the marketplace valuable context for decision-making.

Security & Integration Framework

Security and seamless integration form the foundation of trust within the Student Tank ecosystem. We implement enterprise-grade security with end-to-end encryption using AES-256 standards for all communications, ensuring pitch information remains confidential and intellectual property is protected. Our university verification system creates direct API connections with university entrepreneurship programs to verify student status and project authenticity, building trust in the ecosystem and reducing fraud risk. The platform integrates with secure payment gateways to facilitate investment transactions, incorporating escrow capabilities for phased funding releases based on milestone achievements. This structured approach protects both investors and entrepreneurs throughout the funding process, creating a secure environment for innovation to flourish.

Implementation Strategy

Our technology deployment follows a strategic approach designed to build credibility and ensure platform stability as we scale. We've designed a phased rollout beginning with top 50 universities globally in Phase 1, expanding to 200+ institutions in Phase 2, and implementing open access in Phase 3. This measured expansion allows us to refine our algorithms and user experience based on real-world feedback. The platform is built on a microservices architecture using Docker and Kubernetes, allowing independent scaling of components based on usage patterns. This modern approach ensures flexibility and resilience as the user base grows. We employ continuous performance monitoring through New Relic integration, providing real-time insights into system performance and enabling proactive optimization to maintain a seamless user experience even during periods of high demand.

By leveraging this comprehensive technology stack, Student Tank transforms the traditionally inefficient, biased funding process into a streamlined, merit-based system that dramatically increases access to capital for student entrepreneurs while providing investors with

higher-quality investment opportunities at reduced search costs. Our tools don't merely facilitate connections – they fundamentally reshape how innovation is funded in the academic ecosystem.

Project Plan

Phase 1: Research and Planning (Days 1-3)
Objective: Quickly validate assumptions, define project scope, and set clear goals. Understand the funding gap for student innovation.

Key Activities:

Refine the problem statement based on initial research:
60% of Gen Z wants to start a business, but only 6% receive funding.
Address systemic barriers faced by young founders (access, geography, privilege).

Narrow down the Business Model Canvas to core elements:
Define Value Propositions for both students and investors.
Identify Key Activities (AI matching, pitch platform, identity verification).
Determine Key Resources (AI tech, partnerships, university affiliations).|
Define Customer Segments (students, investors).

Define MVP (Minimum Viable Product) features:
Basic student profile creation with identity verification.
Simple video pitch upload.
Investor profile creation.
Rudimentary AI matching (keyword-based).

Implemented Methods:

Surveys, Stakeholder Interviews, Market Research.
Proposed Methods:: Investor Focus Groups, University Partnership Insights, Competitive Analysis.

Deliverables:
Refined problem statement.
Abbreviated Business Model Canvas.
MVP feature list.
Market Research report summarizing key findings.

Phase 2: Design and Development (Days 4-12)

Objective: Build a functional prototype showcasing core AI matching and pitch capabilities.

Key Activities:
Design basic UI/UX for student/investor profiles and pitch viewing:
Prioritize usability over aesthetics for rapid development.
Develop core AI matching algorithm (simplified version)
Use existing libraries/tools (TensorFlow, BERT) to accelerate development.
Focus on matching based on industry keywords extracted from pitches.
Implement video pitch upload/display functionality:
Utilize a simple video hosting solution (e.g., integration with YouTube).
Implement identity and affiliation verification process for students.

Tech Stack:
AI Matching Engine.
Pitch Video Platform.
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Deliverables:
Functional prototype with core features.
Basic AI matching algorithm.
Video pitch upload/display functionality.

Phase 3: Testing and Quality Assurance (Days 13-15)
Objective: Identify and fix critical bugs. Ensure usability.

Key Activities:
Conduct usability testing with a small group of target users (fellow students)
Focus on identifying pain points in the user flow.
Gather feedback on AI matching accuracy.
Evaluate video upload/display functionality.
Bug fixing and refinement based on user feedback.

Deliverables:
Bug fix list.
Revised prototype based on user feedback.

Phase 4: Launch and Marketing (Days 16-18)
Objective: Introduce the platform to the target audience.

Key Activities:
Launch the platform within the university community.
Create marketing materials targeted at students.
Social media ads highlighting the benefits of Student Tank.
Promotional videos featuring successful student entrepreneurs.
Begin partnerships with university entrepreneurship programs.

Deliverables:

Live platform accessible within the university.
Marketing materials.
Partnerships with university departments.

Phase 5: Continuous Improvement (Days 19-20)
Objective: Plan for ongoing improvements based on initial usage data.

Key Activities:
Monitor user engagement metrics via an analytics dashboard.
Track student registrations.
Monitor pitch uploads.
Analyze investor engagement.
Plan for future updates to the AI algorithms based on initial matching results.
Outline a strategy for expanding the mentor network.

Deliverables:
Plan document for future improvements.

Phase 6: Expansion and Scaling (Future)
Objective: Outline plans for long-term growth and wider adoption.

Key Activities:
Develop a strategy for scaling operations internationally.
Identify potential partnerships with incubators, EdTech platforms, and angel investors globally.
Research new funding models to integrate into the platform.

Deliverables:
Expansion plan document outlining strategies for global reach and new features.

Conclusion:
By enabling student talent outside of conventional startup clusters, Student Tank is transforming innovation funding. It eliminates obstacles like regional restrictions and exclusive networks by establishing a worldwide platform that links student entrepreneurs with investors. Student Tank makes sure that promising ideas get the money and assistance they require to grow through data-driven mentorship and matching initiatives.

Through AI-driven deal discovery, the platform hopes to fund 300% more student initiatives globally by 2026 while cutting investor sourcing expenses by 40%. In order to produce a new generation of prosperous entrepreneurs, it also aims to boost university-led innovation output by 50%. Student Tank demonstrates that innovative ideas can flourish with just the correct venue and no privileged connections by democratizing access to finance.

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